

REVELATIONS 17

70 C.E.¹⁷⁰

¹⁷⁰ You want to fight about it? OK, let's fight:

Verse 10 yields the following chronology:

Augustus – fallen

Tiberius – fallen

Caligula – fallen

Claudius – fallen

Nero – fallen

Vespasian – “one is”

Titus – “has not yet come... a little while” (2 years)

This places the author squarely within Vespasian's reign (69–79 CE), immediately after the Jewish War.

The so-called “Year of the Four Emperors” represents a collapse of legitimacy, not a stable succession, and is routinely excluded in ancient historiography.

Verse 11 reflects the widespread Nero Redivivus expectation, not a Domitianic composition date. The eighth is explicitly said to belong to the seven. That makes it a recurrence, not a successor.

Irenaeus merely reports when the vision was *seen*, not when the text was written... and he does so more than a century later.

1 One of the seven angels who had the seven bowls came and said to me, “Come, I will show you the punishment of the great prostitute, who sits by many waters.

2 With her the kings of the earth committed adultery, and the inhabitants of the earth were intoxicated with the wine of her adulteries.”

3 Then the angel carried me away in the Spirit into a wilderness. There I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast that was covered with blasphemous names and had seven heads and ten horns.

4 The woman was dressed in purple and scarlet, and was glittering with gold, precious stones and pearls. She held a golden cup in her hand, filled with abominable things and the filth of her adulteries.

5 The name written on her forehead was a mystery: Babylon the great the mother of prostitutes and of the abominations of the earth.

6 I saw that the woman was drunk with the blood of God’s holy people, the blood of those who bore testimony to Jesus. When I saw her, I was greatly astonished.

7 Then the angel said to me: “Why are you astonished? I will explain to you the mystery of the woman and of the beast she rides, which has the seven heads and ten horns.

8 The beast, which you saw, once was, now is not, and yet will come up out of the Abyss and go to its destruction. The inhabitants of the earth whose names have not been written in the book of life from the creation of the world will be astonished when they see the beast, because it once was, now is not, and yet will come.

9 “This calls for a mind with wisdom. The seven heads are seven hills on which the woman sits.

10 They are also seven kings. Five have fallen, one is, the other has not yet come; but when he does come, he must remain for only a little while.

The internal evidence is decisive.

11 The beast who once was, and now is not, is an eighth king. He belongs to the seven and is going to his destruction.

12 “The ten horns you saw are ten kings who have not yet received a kingdom, but who for one hour will receive authority as kings along with the beast.

13 They have one purpose and will give their power and authority to the beast.

14 They will wage war against the Lamb, but the Lamb will triumph over them because he is Lord of lords and King of kings—and with him will be his called, chosen and faithful followers.”

15 Then the angel said to me, “The waters you saw, where the prostitute sits, are peoples, multitudes, nations and languages.

16 The beast and the ten horns you saw will hate the prostitute. They will bring her to ruin and leave her naked; they will eat her flesh and burn her with fire.

17 For God has put it into their hearts to accomplish his purpose by agreeing to hand over to the beast their royal authority, until God’s words are fulfilled.

18 The woman you saw is the great city that rules over the kings of the earth.

INTERPRETATION

2026

This chapter is a *layered polemic*. On the surface, historians agree that it is a coded indictment of Roman politics. But beneath that lies a cosmological/mythic critique of imperial power as a recurring spiritual pattern. Then *beneath that* lies a depiction of an ancient and powerful goddess.

That context should immediately answer all questions about why the symbolism is so muddy and why errors exist when you're reading it purely for the third level of symbolism.

ROME

The primary message being communicated uses Babylon purely as a literary device offering a thin veil of deniability over an otherwise scathing critique of Roman politics.

In this sense, Babylon is Rome. The overlap with the spelling of the ancient city is absolutely intentional. Rome destroyed Jerusalem in 70

CE. Calling it *Babylon* draws a tight comparison between Rome and Israel's earlier oppressor.

The reference to "Seven hills" is almost insultingly explicit. Rome was universally known as the city of seven hills.

"Rules over the kings of the earth" is a rather obvious reference to Rome's imperial hegemony.

A PROSTITUTE

In Jewish prophetic language, the concept of *adultery* was actually most closely associated with political idolatry, not literally selling one's body. This definition is still in use today, though it is less common. But still, you might hear of someone being described a "a corporate whore". But in more modern parlance, we might just call it "selling out".

Within the context of Roman politics at the time, this is referring to way that *client kings*¹⁷¹ would be seduced into pledging their loyalty to Rome in exchange for gifts of gold, military protection, and/or access to Rome's religious resources.

THE GOLDEN CUP

The symbolism of the *golden cup* is a reference to Jeremiah 51:7:

Babylon hath been a golden cup in the Lord's hand, that made all the earth drunken: the nations have drunken of her wine; therefore the nations are mad.

When interpreting that verse, bear in mind that the Book of Jeremiah

¹⁷¹ Kings who avoided military invasion by negotiating a puppet state arrangement with Rome.

is in the Old Testament. Therefore, despite referring to Babylon as female, they are merely referring to the city. The use of the feminine pronoun is intended to be an insult.¹⁷²

The meaning is clear: Babylon and Israel are engaged in an ideological war. Thus Babylon's golden cup is filled with the religious ideology of the city of Babylon. The fact that she is getting everyone drunk means that Babylon is winning the war at that point.

Fast-forwarding back to late Roman politics, the phrase "Drunk with the blood of saints" refers to the very real executions of Christians under Nero and Domitian. So yeah, we're mixing metaphors like we mix whiskey and wine. This is John's trailer park and he'll do what he wants!

THE SEVEN KINGS

"Five have fallen, one is, the other has not yet come."

This is where the chapter turns into a timestamped historical journal. The unnamed subject of that sentence is quite obviously a sequence of Roman kings:

Augustus [fallen]

Tiberius [fallen]

Caligula [fallen]

Claudius [fallen]

Nero [fallen]

Vespasian ["one is"]

Titus ["has not yet come... a little while"] (2 years)

¹⁷² I threw up a little in my mouth too.

This places the composition clearly within the reign of emperor Vespasian (69-79 CE), just after the Jewish War.

AN EIGHTH KING?

Verse 11 refers to an eighth king: *“The beast who once was, and now is not, is an eighth king.”*

In this case, the beast is a reference to Nero. It was a widely circulated conspiracy theory at the time that Nero was actually 2Pac and had not really died but was just hidden away somewhere and would return at a later date to retake the throne. This was a such a popular belief that it is referred to by historians as the *Nero Redivivus myth*.

Of course, Nero didn’t return because, like 2Pac, he was dead. So much for the Bible being infallible.¹⁷³

RAISE THE HORNS!

Verse 12 refers to the client kings of Rome. The number ten just means “all of them”; it’s not a literal headcount. They are aligned with Rome only briefly and then they turncoat against the empire.

Symbolically, this represents the prostitute reclaiming her dignity. This is both a key development that saved Israel from certain destruction and an informative lesson about how empires fall at the hands of the very forces they empower. This is very specifically how Rome created the conditions for its own destruction.

¹⁷³ It takes a special kind of stupid...

THE PART YOU CARE ABOUT

Now we get to the image of the woman sitting atop the beast. What this symbolizes is...

Are you ready for it?

Should we take a break and come back to this later?

You're tired aren't you?

Alright, if you insist...

Symbolically, we've moved on from Babylon representing Rome and she's now a full anthropomorphized goddess. As such, her symbolism shifts from local tabloid gossip to universal mechanisms. In this case, she represents the force of legitimacy.

The beast she rides is chaos, violence, coercion, and greed.

By riding the beast, Babylon is translating those forces into something that appears superficially legitimate that people might voluntarily sign up for¹⁷⁴. She is deceptive and leading people to their own demise... but only if they fail to see through the ruse.

Anyone with eyes to see can see that it's a trap. Only those who are blinded by their own greed will fall prey to the trap. This ensures that a certain kind of moral balance is maintained.

A SEXUAL ICON?

Iconographically, we have an image of a goddess who is:

¹⁷⁴ Luxury, status, power, culture, justice, etc.

- Receptive, seductive, beautiful
- Clothed in purple and scarlet (purple = royalty | scarlet = clergy)
- Holding a golden cup (gold = the sun)
- Sitting atop coercive power
- Drunk... but not with wine; with *blood*

This is not *sexual immorality* in the literal sense. Frankly, that nonsense is entirely the product of people trying to speed read the Bible with their brains turned off.

SEVEN HEADS

The first thing that occurs to most readers is that this is a reference to the 7 known planets at that time (in first-century cosmology, the sun and moon were counted as planets; that's how they got to seven). But there were other seven's we could point to also: The seven heavens, the seven angelic governors, etc. Second Temple philosophy loved the number seven.

The text is saying that worldly power is mediated through *cosmic administration*... which has become corrupted. The prostitute has perverted the heavens, turning order into domination.¹⁷⁵

THE WILDERNESS

While certainly a profound insight at the time, it has become a meme today: *You cannot accurately assess a system from within it.* For this reason, John must be taken out of the political strife - by way of a vision - in order to be able to see it clearly.

¹⁷⁵ Sound familiar?

This is basically the same thing that Moses, Elijah, and Jesus did. They needed time apart from the system, meaning that they divested themselves of any personal interest in the politics or other melodrama going on. Only then was the full extent of the corruption laid bare.

APOCALYPSE!

... or perhaps not. This text is not predicting a future apocalypse; it is simply recognizing a pattern:

- Empires present themselves as eternal.
- They intoxicate nations with prosperity.
- They persecute dissenters.
- They rely on delegated power.
- They collapse internally.
- They are replaced by another beast.

The Lamb¹⁷⁶ wins not by replacing the beast, but by refusing its logic.

“Lord of lords” is not meant to be a competing title. it’s a rejection of the entire system.

Probably the most relevant takeaway from this entire chapter for the world today is: *Truth survives empire by outlasting it, not by overthrowing it.* It’s not the most satisfying message ever, but it is what it is.

¹⁷⁶ The proletariat / the common people

BABYLON VS BABALON

2026

Now that Sunday school is over, let's take a look at the symbolism of Babylon and Babalon side-by-side and see if we can sort out just what kind of a lineage we have here. Is it transgressive, satirical, inverted, or perfectly consistent?

BABYLON

I'll spare you a review of the qualities of Babylon. If you haven't read the *Interpretation of Revelations 17*, skip back a few pages and read that first.

The most condensed definition that I can devise is: *Babylon is desire divorced from truth.*

Babylon...

- Receives without discernment
- Beautifies domination
- Makes violence feel meaningful
- Converts force into legitimacy

- Converts suffering into spectacle

Representationally, Babylon is the false grail¹⁷⁷

Symbolically, Babylon is a warning about corrupted receptivity.

BABALON

Let's see whether I can pull out a condensed definition: *Babalon is divine receptivity through radical honesty.*

Babalon, on the other hand...

1. Is naked (conceals nothing)
2. Adorned in scarlet (life, blood, intensity)
3. Holds a golden cup¹⁷⁸
4. Receives all things without preference
5. Is sovereign, not enthroned by force

Clearly, Crowley completely reimagined the symbolism divorced of its original context. Of course he did. What else could he do? Did anyone really expect him to pretend that he was in the midst of first-century roman political turmoil? Or should he have simply updated it to be a metaphor for 20th-century political turmoil?

Well, if he had done that, would you have any reason to care about this subject at all? No, you wouldn't. Crowley knew that and made the right call to recontextualize the symbolism of Babalon along with the helpfully-disambiguating name change to focus on timeless principles.

¹⁷⁷ Her cup is sacred in *form* but poisoned in *content* because it is filled with the blood of her slain enemies.

¹⁷⁸ But this cup is filled in perfect truth via the voluntary surrender of her adorers.

In so doing, it turns out that in many ways Biblical Babylon and Thelemic Babalon are inversions of the same archetype.

THE HOLY GRAIL

Acting as the fulcrum of this archetypal inversion is the imagery of the golden cup (grail):

Babylon's Cup:

- Gold on the outside, filth inside
- Intoxicates the nations
- Induces unconscious participation
- Masks coercion as desire
- Functions as an instrument of empire

Babalon's Cup:

- Receives all blood indiscriminately
- No pretense of purity or righteousness
- Applies no moral filtering
- Functions as instrument of truth

Babalon *justifies nothing* but she *reveals everything*.

THE BEAST

Babylon:

- Sits on the Beast
- She needs the Beast
- She legitimizes the Beast
- She exploits the Beast
- She is destroyed by the Beast

Babylon's power is conditional upon the Beast.

Babalon:

- Rides the Beast
- Is the active complement to the Beast's power
- Directs the Beast's power without dominating it
- Integrates and focuses the Beast's Will

REDEMPTION

Babylon is *condemned* because:

- She feigns innocence
- She launders violence
- She claims purity while consuming blood

Babalon is *exalted* because:

- She makes no claim to innocence
- She hides nothing
- She asks for total responsibility

Babalon offers no victimization, no absolution, no deception... only truth.

DESTRUCTION

Where Babalon lives on in truth, Babylon, both as a city and as a goddess, died. However, just like Lil Peep, she keeps releasing new songs!

As a metaphor for Rome, she was conquered and destroyed.
As a metaphor for political power, she is a lifecycle that, unfortunately, continues to churn.

The Beast, in this sense, represents the actual empires she creates.
In the end, Babylon is always consumed by the Beast because *force eventually rejects the illusion that once justified it.*